

"To be successful in life what you need is education."

PEN DRIVE WRITER

The Gandhian-turned-socialist took literature to the common man by writing about their concerns in a language they could understand

■ By Megha Anwer

Dhanpat Rai, better known as Munshi Premchand, may well be credited with the Lukacsian nomenclature—a socialist realist writer. He mercilessly exposed the structures of oppression that afflicted rural India—poverty, exploitation of Dalits, superstition, religious rituals, patriarchy, zamindari system, colonialism and communalism.

Before Premchand, writing in Hindi was highly Sanskritised and had little relation to reality. He reversed this by writing about common people and in a simple, colloquial dialect. Often, Premchand is mistaken for a Gandhian. Early in his career, he envisaged a Gandhian scenario where the oppressors would, almost through magical intervention, cease their crimes

against humanity. But his later writings show a shift to socialist ideology. In a conversation with Marathi writer T. Tikekar, he declared: "I am a communist, but my communism is limited only to the extent that the zamindars, seths and others, the exploiters of the peasants, should cease to exist."

Similarly, Premchand's attitude towards the Indian national movement was neither uncritical nor blindly lauding. As noted critic Sudhir Chandra argues, if in his short stories like *Tavan* (1931) and *Ahuti* (1930) nationalism is depicted as "attractive and inspiring" then in his novels like

Munshi Premchand

Writer 1880-1936

Rangbhum (1925) and *Karmabhumi* (1932) he unveils the "sordid reality behind the ideological facade". He was critical of the movement turning into an occasion for the dominant class to propagate its class interests.

From the feminist perspective, Premchand has received strong criticism. Charu Gupta accuses him of categorising his women protagonists into simplistic binaries. On one hand, they represent the ideal, suffering mother figures who become upholders of a feudal value system that valorises chastity and feminine passivity. On the

other hand, the antithesis to the ideal woman is the "counter-model" of the westernised woman—assertive, independent and sexualised. While this critique is legitimate he was aware that if poor men suffered then their women counterparts suffered twice over. His novels *Godan*, *Gaban* and *Nirmala* are hard-hitting while his short stories are a scathing attack on the forces of subjugation in colonial India. What is most striking, and perhaps the cause of Premchand's continuing relevance, is that the issues he raised as challenges for India, continue to daunt us even today.

The writer teaches at Lady Sri Ram College, Delhi University



Q: On whose call did he quit his job as teacher?

A: Mahatma Gandhi!

Q: Name his works filmed by Satyajit Ray.

A: *Shatranj ke Khiladi*, *Sadgati*

Q: Which anthology was labelled seditious by the British?

A: *Soz-e-Watan*

